Nizamuddin Ahmad: Rose to the high post of bakshi in Akbar's army during the later years of the long Gujarat campaign. Wrote the most dispassionate contemporary account of the first forty-odd years of Akbar's reign, the *Tabakat-i Akbari*

Shaikh Abdun Nabi: Akbar's sadr, chief justice. A powerful scholar and jurist until he fell out of favour, was exiled, and later imprisoned and murdered

Makhdum-ul-Mulk (Maulana Abdullah Ansari): A leader of the ulema in the Suri court, remained powerful in the first half of Akbar's reign. Was exiled along with Shaikh Abdun Nabi. Died of fright when arrested

Muhammad Yazd: A Shia scholar in Akbar's court. Initially favoured by Akbar, but later issued a fatwa encouraging rebellion against the emperor. Drowned in an 'accident' possibly engineered by Akbar

Pir Muhammad: Bairam Khan's arrogant and bloodthirsty deputy. Was exiled by Bairam Khan but returned as a commander to Akbar's court after the regent's downfall. Drowned in the Narmada when his horse was bit by a camel

Asaf Khan (Khwaja Abdul Majid): A clerk in Humayun's court. Became a military commander under Akbar. Led the conquest of Rani Durgavati's kingdom. Joined the Uzbek rebellion, but only briefly

Baba Khan Qaqshal: Leader of the Qaqshal clan of warlords who settled in eastern Hindustan and led the Bengal rebellion – the last serious attempt by Akbar's nobility to remove him from the throne

Shahbaz Khan: A hot-tempered Punjabi commander in Akbar's court; instrumental in subduing the Bengal rebellion

Todar Mal: Star financial adviser, reformer and general in Akbar's court. Led Akbar's armies (including against the Bengal rebels) as well as he led many of Akbar's administrative and revenue reforms

Muzaffar Khan: Another of Akbar's star financial advisers. Often fell out of favour because of his blunt manner. Redeemed himself with military success in the east. Executed by the Bengal rebels

Shah Mansur: One of Akbar's great accountants (and, like all his great accountants, greatly unpopular with Akbar's nobility). Was hanged at